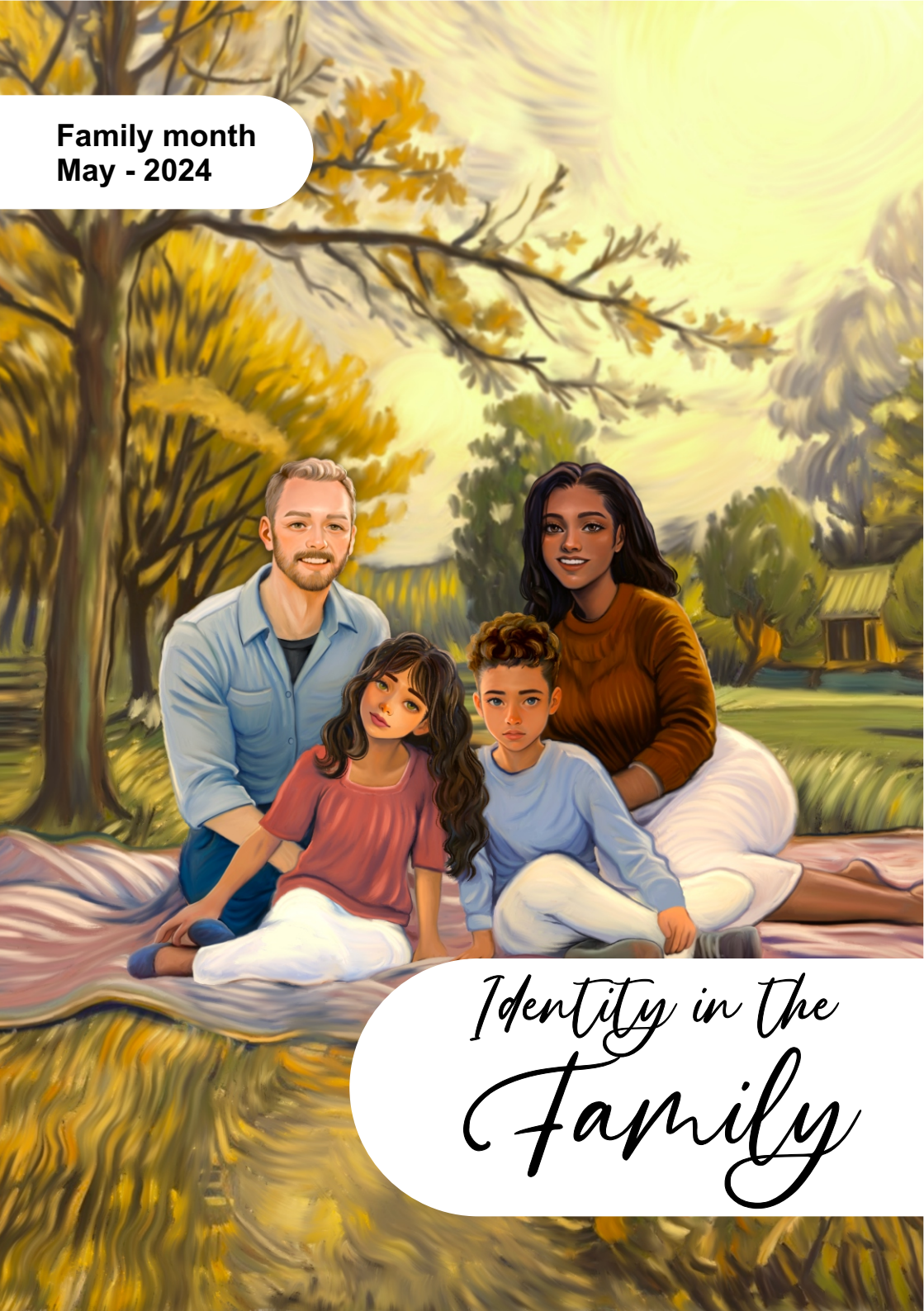


An oil painting of a family of four sitting on a pink and white striped blanket in a park. The father, with a beard and short brown hair, wears a light blue button-down shirt and blue pants. The mother, with long dark hair, wears a brown sweater and white pants. They have a daughter with long dark hair in a red shirt and white pants, and a son with curly brown hair in a light blue shirt and white pants. The background features large trees with yellow and green leaves, a small wooden house, and a bright, hazy sky.

**Family month
May - 2024**

*Identity in the
Family*

Acknowledgement

My special thanks to the translators, proofreaders, editors, publishers, layout designers, publicists. Thanks to their efforts and excellent work the Family Readings will be translated into more than 25 languages. God bless you.
Philippians 4:19.

Director of the General Conference Family Department.

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International Missionary Society Seventh-Day Adventist Reform Movement



625 West Avenue Cedartown, GA 30125

EE.UU.

Phone: (+1) 770-748 0077

E-mail: info@sda1844 | www.sda1844.org

Our digital channels

Illustrator (images): Ítalo Israel Santos Silva
Vitória da Conquista - Brazil
Instagram: @italoisrael



Familias con Jesús

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INTRODUCTION

In heaven, everything was happiness, nothing disturbed the joy and stability of the place. God communicated freely with all the holy angels, and the divine government was loved and respected by all the angelic orders of the universe. In that wonderful place, in the mind of God, the matchless idea of creating the holy couple was born. Man and woman were created as the crown of creation, perfect, free, thinking and acting beings, with holy values and principles. As they came to life, joy radiated from their countenances; they were created to fulfil the divine purpose and form a home for the glory of the Lord. God created the family in His image and likeness, with the purpose that it would always be under His blessing, thus ensuring its prosperity and consecration to live eternally.

However, danger lurked in one of the beings created by the Divine hand, who decided to rebel against his Maker, and thus, sin was first introduced into heaven and then onto the earth, affecting the holy couple. This evil being decided to destroy not only the image and identity of a considerable number of angels who fell with him in rebellion but also of the created couple. In this way, God's plan for man was blurred, and if it had not been for the intervention of the unmatched plan of redemption, humanity would have perished without any hope. Glory to God for His ineffable gift in providing such a magnificent salvation!

According John 10:10, "The thief comes only to steal, kill, and destroy..."; the enemy came to kill and take away the identity of human beings through destructive theories. Thus, evil was introduced into culture, education, false religions, various forms of technology, false science, politics, mistaken ideologies in health sciences, distorted mind sciences, the practice of yoga, and even into the minds of children and youth, manipulating consciences to benefit false worldly systems of global dominion, among others.

Brothers and sisters, we live in difficult times in which our families are being attacked from all sides. For this reason, the Family Department makes an urgent call to people, families, and the church to personally reconnect with Christ and return to the original design of creation. Ephesians 2:10 says, "For we are His workmanship, created in Christ Jesus for good works..."

We long for every member and each family to return to an intimate relationship with God, to be strengthened, and to recover their identity in Christ. By restoring our relationship and identity with God, the result will be happy men and women, at peace, confident, with balanced and stable mental health, contributing to a harmonious church that glorifies its Creator.

Likewise, we invite you to participate in the series of readings for May 2024, prepared by the General Conference Family Department. These readings should be read in all churches and groups worldwide. It is our wish and prayer that they serve as a tool for each reader to find their identity in Jesus Christ.



Your Own IDENTITY in the Light of God

By
Sis. Ines Mueller

Who I am? What sets me apart from others? People begin to ask themselves these questions at an early age and achieve some clarity in their youth; however, they continue to develop. Each generation of philosophers and psychologists seems to have their own ideas about identity.¹ Which of them will last? In the Bible, we have the most competent counselor: our Creator. In His Word, everyone can find, discover, amaze, and accept themselves. However, it's also about being surrounded by other unique human beings.

What exactly is identity?

The word identity comes from the Latin "idem", which means "equal, the same." Human identity means conformity to oneself and is the expression of a person's distinctive character. To identify someone means to recognize them unmistakably.

Who am I?

A mirror can not show what truly defines a person since what really matters most are their thoughts and desires, interests and preferences, temperament, gifts and abilities, language, and actions. The mirror barely reflects the traces left behind by socialization, experiences, and the influence of others. Fears and worries, hopes and plans are not revealed by the image in the mirror. What is not immediately recognizable seems to be the deciding factor: temperament, character, and overall personality. We want to define the concepts that surround identity.

Temperament is "a person's inner experience in response to their environment and, derived from it, their behavior."²

Character describes the mental and emotional traits of a person, which can be innate or acquired, and determine their behavior and shape their personality.³

Personality and character are often used synonymously. "But there is only one Model from which human character must be formed - the character of Christ."⁴

To sum up all characteristics and traits, a person's individuality is unique and unmistakable.⁵

Identity consists of all these components, and it also wants to know: "Where do I belong?". To put it briefly, identity is the answer to the questions: "Who, what, how, and where am I?". "Each one of us has an individuality, an identity that cannot be surrendered to any other human being. We are individually the workmanship of God." -Letter 92, 1895".⁶ "God has given each one, men and women, an identity, an individuality."⁷

What does the Bible say about our identity?

We can learn the most important thing about our identity in the first pages of the Bible: "*So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him....*" (Genesis 1:27).

Our heavenly Father created, gifted, and endowed each of us, making us unique creatures of God. We can express it like King David: "*I will praise thee; for I am fearfully and wonderfully made...*" (Psalm 139:14).

Our being is rooted in God's plan. Regardless of the differences we feel and have, all people are equal. God did not plan any classification based on origin, skin color, or sex. How do you imagine Adam and Eve were? Yes, they were perfect. But what does that mean? Doesn't each era and each nationality have its own idea of perfection and run the risk of building walls and marginalizing those who do not conform to a supposed ideal? Man pays too much attention to outward appearances, but "*... the Lord looks at the heart*" (1 Samuel 16:7). That is why people should not seek an identity isolated from inner values, neither in themselves nor in others. The fact that our identity is linked to our inner being is demonstrated by this testimony: "They may have been deformed, diseased, or disfigured in this mortal life, and arise in perfect health and symmetry; yet in the glorified body their identity will be perfectly preserved."⁸

The first human beings lost their perfection, their sinless identity, because of their fall due to disobedience. Since then, God has offered people an identity that includes forgiveness of transgression and a life that struggles against sin.

Everyone continues to carry a portion of the "image of God" within them. God's identity includes his free will with the ability to decide. Imagination and creativity are also closely linked to creation. Even people who base their lives on other worldviews retain these identity characteristics. However, they forget God as their source.

Our abilities and skills, experiences and tasks, living environment and peers, marriage and family, physical condition, and other details influence and shape our identity. "*And there are diversities of operations, but it is the same God which worketh all in all. But the manifestation of the Spirit is given to every man to profit withal.*" (1 Corinthians 12:6, 7). The Russian writer Dostoevsky realized that: "To love a person is to see him as God intended him to be."⁹ According to the commandment "love your neighbor as you love yourself," you cannot love yourself unless you see yourself as God intended you to be.

Our identity as Christians must be developed according to the light of the Bible, because "*All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That*

the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works." (2 Timothy 3:16, 17). "Christians will display a holy character and their actions and impulses will be motivated by the Holy Spirit." -ST, August 6, 1912

Our Christian Identity can be Summarized as:

We are all God's creatures¹² but we are invited to be more. We may acknowledge that we are God's property and as a new creation,¹³ through conversion,¹⁴ we are his children.¹⁵ We are forgiven sinners¹⁶ if we call Jesus our friend¹⁷ and we are redeemed¹⁸ through Him. For others, we are "salt and light"¹⁹, "ambassadors of God"²⁰, and "epistle of Christ"²¹. As heavenly citizens,²² we wait for the return of Jesus²³ and eternal life.²⁴ We are loved by God,²⁵ desired²⁶, and valuable to our heavenly Father.²⁷

Gender Identity

Everything that is exaggerated quickly becomes imbalanced. These days it seems difficult for many people to find their identity, especially when it comes to gender. The topic occupies an important place in media, society, and children's education. However, we will not try to clarify the problem from a medical or psychological point of view. Instead, we should heed advice that is almost 3,000 years old: "... *Inquire, I pray thee, at the word of the Lord today.*" (1 Kings 22:5). When the first humans emerged from the hand of God, His quality control was "very good."²⁸ Adam and Eve, man and woman, were completely perfect. Were they happy? "...Everything God had made was in the perfection of beauty, and there seemed nothing wanting upon the earth which God had created to make Adam and Eve happy..."²⁹

It seems increasingly more difficult to develop a masculine identity or know what that's like. Softy or macho? Our society works with extremes and clichés. Sometimes there are sharp distinctions between the sexes, while other times all differences are negated. Increasingly, young people suffer psychologically and physically in their process of self-discovery and develop, for example, an eating disorder.³⁰ Old knowledge is confirmed today: Boys and girls develop very differently.³¹

God gave us his Word to give "... *the young man knowledge and discretion*" (Proverbs 1:4). The Bible dispels the ideas with which boys and men are generally identified. Characteristics such as: hard, callous, impulsive, aggressive, irresponsible, and negligent of duty are things that in the eyes of the world may give the image of a "well-rounded guy," but that is not how the

Bible describes a "*man according to God's heart.*" In 1 Samuel 13:14, we learn that Saul's reign would not last. God chose "a man after his own heart" because Saul did not keep God's command. A man after God's own heart is one who is obedient to God. That must be the goal for our children's identity, that they become men after the heart of God "*... be thou strong therefore, and shew thyself a man; and keep the charge of the Lord thy God, to walk in his ways,*" (1 Kings 2:2, 3). What exactly should boys learn? Meekness and humility³² so that "*...we all come in the unity of the faith, and of the knowledge of the Son of God, unto a perfect man, unto the measure of the stature of the fulness of Christ*" (Ephesians 4:13).

"All the powers of mind and body should be called into active exercise that the youth may become strong, well-balanced men and women." —The Signs of the Times, June 29, 1882.³³

Be Happy to be a Woman

The past and present are characterized by women's oppression. The experiences and feelings of many women range from disempowerment and lack of rights to perceptions of being less valuable and injustices in family life, in the job market, and sometimes in the church as well. Girls continue looking for guidelines, wondering about values, and dreaming of a happy life. I asked girls and women of different ages in church: "Who has ever thought: Oh, I wish I had been a boy!"? Almost all of them responded affirmatively! I also see this as a responsibility of the church.

When I was born, my grandmother said, "She's just a girl!". Did Jesus see me like that? How could I experience, as a child and teenager, that God had created something wonderful when he created me? My parents showed me how much they loved me. I never heard them say, "We really wanted a son, and then you came along." Later when I heard the Bible stories and read them myself, I realized how Jesus perceived women and showed them that he was their Savior, that he loved them. A woman was the first to learn that the Messiah would soon come into this world as a little child, Mary. She summarized how we should behave towards Jesus: "Do what He tells you." It was mainly women who were at the foot of the cross and it was women who were the first to communicate with the risen Savior. The Christian proclamation began with women. I was able to consider all this when I recognized myself as a woman. As women, we are neither a shadow of a man nor a pale copy. We are special and valuable. I am, and you are!, created with

so many abilities with gifts and possibilities, both mental and physical, with imagination and dreams, empathy, emotions, and humor, with the ability to make good decisions and follow the ways of the Lord. Jesus wants us to recognize our tasks, be creative, take responsibility, and be successful. God does not want it to be difficult for you to live as a woman, instead, we should be grateful and find our identity in Christ. He is our Creator, Companion, Friend, and Savior. The Savior gives us an identity that allows us to be happy. Never forget: you are one of God's wonderful ideas. Jesus wants to spend eternity with you. Dare to develop as the woman God intended you to be within your family and neighborhood. Cling to Christ in every situation, because He gives you your identity as His daughter!

Not equal, but of equal value "...male and female he created them" (Genesis 1:27)

Adam and Eve, created in the image of God, had divine traits. However, the fall of man destroyed harmony and created division. If God created women and men as counterparts, then both can meet eye to eye! When we talk about the Sabbath and health reform, we often say: "Go to the Garden of Eden!", and also when talking about gender identity: "Go to the Garden of Eden!" See God's loving thoughts when considering the relationship between man and woman. Fulfill God's will, and you may already have a little piece of heaven on earth!

"Eve was created from a rib taken from the side of Adam, signifying that she was not to control him as the head, nor to be trampled under his feet as an inferior, but to stand by his side as an equal, to be loved and protected by him. A part of man, bone of his bone, and flesh of his flesh, she was his second self..."¹¹³⁴

"There is neither Jew nor Greek, there is neither bond nor free, there is neither male nor female: for ye are all one in Christ Jesus." (Galatians 3:28). Men and women are not equal - but of equal value, not boringly equal - but interestingly different, not separate from each other - but complementary. We are uniquely different, which is why: *"...accept one another, just as Christ also accepted us, for the glory of God."* (Romans 15:7, NASB)

God created man and woman - why this dichotomy?

"...male and female he created them" (Genesis 1:27). Neither man nor woman can independently reflect the image of God in his fullness. Both are necessary so that through their differences they complement each other and come to reflect the image of God. It is not so much about physical differences

but about the whole spiritual and mental realm. Women are not men with the additional function of giving birth. God has created women in their entirety (thinking, feeling, way of acting...) as uniquely as men, not less valuable.

Those who value themselves know how they can be of help to others. This knowledge drives us to be empathetic and is necessary so that love for our neighbor is filled with works of love; as John writes: "*Beloved, I wish above all things that thou mayest prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospereth.*" (3 John 2). Help one another to develop their identity according to God's light and discover your unique personality. Amen.

Notes:

- 1 See <https://www.philomag.de/lexikon/identitaet> downloaded on: 3.10.23
- 2 <https://www.wortbedeutung.info/Temperament/> downloaded on: 3.10.23
- 3 See <https://www.wortbedeutung.info/Charakter/> downloaded on: 3.10.23
- 4 E.G. White, *Adventist Bible Commentary*, volume 6, p. 1098.
- 5 See <https://www.values-academy.de/individualitaet/> downloaded on: 3.10.23
- 6 E.G. White, *Letters and Manuscripts — Volume 10 (1895)*
- 7 E.G. White, *Letters to Young Lovers*, 1987, p. 48.
- 8 E.G. White, *Last Day Events*, p. 295.
- 9 <https://www.aphorismen.de/zitat/150308> accessed on: 5.10.23.
- 10 See Matthew 22:39.
- 11 E.G. White, *Mind, Character and Personality*, volume 2, p. 573.
- 12 See Psalm 139:14.
- 13 See 2 Corinthians 5:17.
- 14 See Luke 15:7.
- 15 See 1 John 3:1.
- 16 See Titus 2:11, 12.
- 17 See John 15:14.
- 18 See Ephesians 1:7.
- 19 See Matthew 5:13, 14.
- 20 See 2 Corinthians 5:20.

- 21 See 2 Corinthians 3:2.
- 22 See Philippians 3:20.
- 23 See 2 Peter 3:13.
- 24 See Titus 1:2.
- 25 See Jeremiah 31:3.
- 26 See Psalm 139.
- 27 See Isaiah 43:4.
- 28 See Genesis 1:31.
- 29 E.G. White, *The Truth about Angels*, p. 53.
- 30 See d o w n l o a d e d
<https://de.statista.com/themen/10246/essstoerungen/#topicOverview>
on: 8.10.23.
- 31 *Central German newspaper*, 08/12/2006, p. 11.
- 32 See Matthew 11:28, 29.
- 33 E.G. White, *Mind, Character and Personality*, volume 1, p. 188.
- 34 E.G. White, *Letters to Young Lovers*, 1987, p. 11.

The Bible verses have been taken from the King James Bible unless another version is indicated.



2

Thursday, May 9

Our Children's IDENTITY

According to God

By
Pr. Nicolás Anca

But ye are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a peculiar people; that ye should shew forth the praises of Him who hath called you out of darkness into His marvellous light." **1 Peter 2:9**

My dear brothers and sisters, dear youth and children, dear families; greetings in the wonderful and blessed Name of Jesus Christ, our Lord and Saviour. I hope and pray that this message will help you to find your

identity in Christ, and answer to your questions that you might have, what's the purpose of God in my life? How can I fulfill it?

Jesus as our perfect example

When we look at the Scriptures and ask ourselves, what was Jesus like as a Child? Was he happy in His home? How about the relationship He had with His earthly parents? Was he tempted like we are? How about the attractions of this world? And so many things that someone born in this world may go through. John, the beloved disciple tells us in **John 21:25** that there were so many remarkable things in the life of Jesus Christ, that if they were all written down, the volumes would be beyond measure. Thank God we have the four Gospels in which we can learn a lot about the birth, childhood, and adulthood of our Lord, and His great work in the redemption of humanity. A very important glimpse into the life of Jesus as a child is when we read in the Gospel of **Luke 2:49** "... be about My Father's business." This fact shows us the deep spiritual understanding and desire to be in the "business of His Father" He knew exactly the purpose and meaning of His life., and He never has been distracted or departed from achieving and fulfilling His Father's plan for His life, for humanity, for you and me as a family in Christ.

A very remarkable statement about the life of Jesus, the servant of the Lord, Ellen White wrote; "The childhood and youth of Jesus were spent in a little mountain village. There was no place on earth that would not have been honored by His presence. The palaces of kings would have been privileged in receiving Him as a guest. But He passed by the homes of wealth, the courts of royalty, and the renowned seats of learning, to make His home in obscure and despised Nazareth. Wonderful in its significance is the brief record of His early life: "The child grew, and waxed strong in spirit, filled with wisdom: and the grace of God was upon Him." In the sunlight of His Father's countenance, Jesus "increased in wisdom and stature, and in favor with God and man." **Luke 2:52**. His mind was active and penetrating, with a thoughtfulness and wisdom beyond His years. Yet His character was beautiful in its symmetry. The powers of mind and body developed gradually, in keeping with the laws of childhood.

As a child, Jesus manifested a peculiar loveliness of disposition. His willing hands were ever ready to serve others. He manifested a patience that

nothing could disturb, and a truthfulness that would never sacrifice integrity. In principle firm as a rock, His life revealed the grace of unselfish courtesy.” (*Desire of Ages*, page 69)

Dear families in Christ, I am asking us: do we know our true identity? Is my family, your family identified in Christ? Dear youth, what is your destination and aim in this life? Will you now reject the crown of life which the Lord has prepared for you? Why should we refuse the service with which the Lord has commissioned us? Have we not been partakers of great and precious privileges in the knowledge of the Truth? Should we not pass them on to others? These are few questions that we are called to meditate upon. Even though if your abilities are not as great, you may still place them at the disposal of the Lord. There are many possibilities, remember that all the gifts we have received from the Lord, whether they be spiritual or material, should be used to the glory of the Lord.

21st Century World Living and its Impact on our Children

21ST Century or the third millennium as it is called, and the time in which we are living brought a lot of changes in our modern society, in the religious, scientific, political, economic, and environmental world. The transition from the end of the 20th and the beginning of the 21st century was marked by tremendous change, at least in three aspects, in the religious world, technology advancement, and leisure time, as so many young and adults are looking for. When I look at how this society categorize and talk about some of the human values, for example; freedom, respect, community and responsibility, aren't they found in the Bible? Yes, they are. God is committed to freedom, He created us with the freedom of choice. God is not coercing anyone, but Satan does, he coerces people. God wants us to respect each other, the fifth commandment says “Honour thy father and thy mother” and it's followed by a promise, and it's our duty that should be motivated by love when we honour and respect our parents while they are alive. Jesus has done that throughout all His life on earth as we read in the Bible and Testimonies. He created us to live together in peace and harmony as a community of believers looking for opportunities to help others, and being responsible for our actions. New economic, social, scientific and religious ideas are rubbing and bending the traditional values that faithful Christians

through the centuries have lived and died for.

But when we look through the window of this world today, we see our world is filled with conflict, division and war. Worry, anxiety, fear and hopelessness have led millions to experience major depression which affects more than 20% of the world's population at some point in their lives. There is a conflict in the families in our day and age. Mankind seems to be helplessly divided among nations, cultures, religions and their underlying values. Peace and reconciliation do not appear to be attainable. Society and people see the world through their own sets of values and perspectives, but not through God's values as given in the Scriptures. When we look at the continuing conflict in the Middle East and other places of the world, what do we see? Exactly what the Bible predicted in the end-time events prior Jesus 2nd coming. Jesus describes natural disasters, including pestilences that devastate the earth in the context of the signs of His 2nd coming. But let me ask this question; what do men and women, the youth need in this 21st century

most? If you were starving, it might be food, if you were homeless, it might be a place to live. If you were lonely and discouraged, it might be love. But one thing people need most, people all over the world need to have the hope of Jesus soon returning. Hope looks beyond the difficulties of this life to a better tomorrow. But we are in a crisis today.

The Religious Crisis

In the midst of the flames and crisis of our age, there are thousands of our young people striving to find purpose and meaning to life. Religion only, does not make anyone better, the Pharisees tried that and failed. Sometimes parents fail in educating their children for Heaven because they try to do it according to their own ideas and theories, sometimes inherited from their parents which failed as well. Sometimes we may do even our best and there still is emptiness and disorientation in the life of our children. The Bible tells us in the book of **Proverbs 22:6** "Train up a child in the way he should go, and when he is old, he will not depart from it." It doesn't say bring your child to Church only, it says "train up" and this is a very interesting word and very important, this word has to do with study, practice or exercise all you have learnt for the Christian character development. We have to repeat it sometimes until it becomes a good habit

in the life of our children.

The servant of the Lord said in *Desire of Ages, page 70*: “Every child may gain knowledge as Jesus did. As we try to become acquainted with our heavenly Father through His word, angels will draw near, our minds will be strengthened, our characters will be elevated and refined.”

My dear parents, ministers, Bible school Instructors if our children and youth in our homes, churches or Missionary Schools do not find love, acceptance, understanding and support in our relationship with them then they go in searching for those values in some other places, and most of the time they end up in wrong places ruining their lives and the lives of others. I know that we try to do our best in these institutions I have mentioned, but the reality is that they feel that way, we still see them not walking happy with the Lord, sometimes their feelings and inclinations are more in the world than in the Lord. We don't want that to happen, but it does sometimes and we can avoid it if we pay attention to word of God and His instructions carefully. If we do not teach them by precept and example then they will say this is hypocrisy, and we cannot stop them in pursuing their own ambitions for this life now and here. I heard so many times the expression “we have done everything for them” when I talked to parents that are in a situation in which a son or daughter left the Church. But have we? I have two sons, and sometimes when they commit some mistakes, I am tempted to say the same, and that's a wrong diagnosis and approach from our site if that happens. My dear brothers and sisters, we need more patience with our Children, we need to learn how to love them even when they have made wrong choices in life, they need us to be there for them and show them the love of Christ. How many educators in this world consider the great ultimate situations of human life, death, suffering, sin and salvation – worthy of study? Modern educators avoid these issues and side-steps the ultimate realities of life. This is the great reason why modern education is losing its grip on the modern student and they have this misunderstanding and misconception of the reality of life, according to God's plan.

The Social-Media Danger

Statistics tell us that teenagers who use social media for three or more hours every day are at an increased risk of depression, anxiety, and other

mental health related problems. These negative effects include addiction, the decline face-to-face communication, self-esteem issues, social isolation and so many other elements that deteriorate relationships between parents and children. Today, 97% of teens say they use the internet daily. The number of teens who say they are online “almost constantly” has doubled over the last 10 years to 46%. Suicide is the second-leading cause of death among the youth that according to statistics increased with 40% in the last 10 years. Drop-off schools and so many other issues related to the social-media abuse, I don't want to say that all social-media is bad that's why I called it “abuse”. There are good things in it when we connect in morning and evening worship, Mornings with God, Pleading with God, Prayer Meeting in zoom, YouTube or Facebook. There are good things we can do in social-media if used correct. We can preach the Gospel in giving Bible studies online, make friends for Jesus inviting them to attend our Church services. That's the way to fill that emotional emptiness when you feel that way. The Bible gives us very good and healthy guidelines even though this world is in a continuing changing God never change. I will share with you at least four aspects of unchanging things about God.

1. The Character of God. Malachiah 3:6 “I AM THE LORD, I CHANGE NOT” James 1:17 we are told “Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and cometh down from the Father of lights, with who is no variableness, neither shadow of turning.”
2. God's Love doesn't Change. 1 John 4:8 “God is love” Jeremiah 31:3 “I have loved you with an everlasting love, therefore with lovingkindness have I drawn thee.”
3. God's Word Never Changes. Isaiah 40:8 “The grass withereth, the flower fadeth; but the word of our God shall stand forever.” Psalm 119:89 “Forever, o Lord, Thy word is settled in heaven.”
4. The Promise of Jesus 2nd Coming doesn't change. He will come just as He said it.
John 14:1-3 Jesus promised that He will come again to take us home where a place is prepared for us. Do you believe all these wonderful things about our heavenly Father?

Our society has departed from the precepts of God and this world is in a continuing spiritual decline of human personality and human responsibility, and this society in term seems to be ruled by the computer, fashion, social-media and big corporations that control the world, and we are in the midst of it all, what can we do? Well, there is way out and that's in the Bible. As diligent students of the Scriptures we have to come before God with modesty and humility of Christ so that we can receive power and strength in these last days of earth's history, and know for ourselves how to use our time and influence. The Scripture tells us "I will give them a heart that they may know Me". **Jeremiah 24:7** Have you taken the time to know Jesus personally? How about us as parents? Are we carrying parent responsibilities in a Christ-like manner because we are told that Christian parents who carry on their parenting responsibilities dutifully in Christlike authority may succeed in raising and training up well-balanced children in mind and spirit. The Bible tells us, "Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of lights with whom there is no variation or shadow due to change." **James 1:17**

I want to conclude this message with few statements by the servant of the Lord "What is the great aim and object of their education? Is it to fit them for life and its duties, to qualify them to take an honorable position in the world, to do good, to benefit their fellow-beings, to gain eventually the reward of righteousness? If so, then the first lesson to be taught is self-control, for no undisciplined, headstrong person can hope for success in this world or reward in the next." **(Child Guidance, page 91.1)**

"Neglect of duty, injudicious indulgence, failure to correct the follies of youth, will result in unhappiness and finally ruin to the children and disappointment and anguish to the parents. **(Child Guidance, page 258.1)**

My dear brothers and sisters, the Bible tells us that children are God's heritage given to parents, let us be careful how we bring them up, how we treat them. Dear children and youth the Lord invites you to come closer to Jesus and His word, to study the Testimonies carefully and apply the beautiful teachings to your lives. Both parents and children want to go to heaven when Jesus comes for the 2nd time. Let us learn from the perfect example of our Lord and Saviour is my wish and prayer. AMEN!

Jesus is our example. There are many who dwell with interest upon the period of His public ministry, while they pass unnoticed the teachings of

His early years. But it is in His home life that He is the pattern for all children and youth. The Saviour condescended to poverty, that He might teach how closely we in a humble lot may walk with God. He lived to please, honor, and glorify His Father in the common things of life. His work began in consecrating the lowly trade of the craftsman who toil for their daily bread. He was doing God's service just as much when labouring at the carpenter's bench as when working miracles for the multitude. And every youth who follows Christ's example of faithfulness and obedience in His lowly home may claim those words spoken of Him by the Father through the Holy Spirit, "Behold My Servant, whom I uphold; Mine elect in whom My soul delighted." Isaiah 42:1 (***Desire of Ages, page 74***).
Amen.

3

Friday, May 10



The IDENTITY of a Woman, According to God

By
Pr. Adalicio Fontes

So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him, male and female created he them.” Genesis 1:27. This text shows us a truth that orientates and directs the identity's search of every human being. We were created in the image of God. Men and women have the distinctive seal of divine intelligence that differentiates us from other living beings and allows us to show the image of God in us. This happens in a wonderful way as we relate to Him and to each other, thus learning to be leaders of a higher order and to govern the creation with

wisdom. In no other place do we find more dignity than in the fact that we have been created to the image of our Creator.

In the plan of God, women occupy an irreplaceable place that is very well defined by heaven. At the beginning of Hebrew civilization, the women of the patriarchs were matriarchs, they were women that were listened, respected and admired. There were women prophetesses and judges. Women were present in the mount Sinah in the moment that God talked to Moses and made the people of Israel a chosen people. They participated actively in religious celebrations and politic acts. They had a voice, in the public sphere as much as in the private. With time and due to foreign influences, they were excluded from the public activity and were confined to the home.

As time went by and civilizations began, they started to be defined by their biological aspect, as childbearing mothers, depending first from the father and later from the husband. But this was not the will of God for the female gender, the following text expresses it clearly: "The Christian mother's sphere of usefulness should not be narrowed by her domestic life. The salutary influence which she exerts in the home circle she may and will make felt in more widespread usefulness in her neighborhood and in the church of God. Home is not a prison to the devoted wife and mother." {AH236.3}

This text outlines that the function and usefulness of a Christian mother should not be limited to their domestic life. The positive influence that she practices in her family can be extended further, impacting the community and the church in a beneficial way. It is sustainable that the home should not be perceived like a prison for the dedicated mother and wife, but as a place from where she can emanate a positive influence that goes beyond the family boundaries. The woman is an image of God, the crown of the creation, created to live in communion with Him, she is a help meet, she has been created to give life, and she is necessary to extend the heavenly kingdom.

God's Masterpiece

And the rib, which the LORD God had taken from man, made he a woman, and brought her unto the man. And Adam said, This is now bone of my bones, and flesh of my flesh: she shall be called Woman, because she was taken out of Man. Genesis 2:22,23

God created the woman as a perfect masterpiece. He made on her a

wonderful design, giving her high capacities and important virtues to praise her Creator.

The nature of God is love and with this love, He created her with a specific purpose. The key point

in your identity is to discover who you are and how you project yourself to the world. We can see in Genesis that only with man, the creation was not complete. For this reason, God decided to create the woman so the man would not be alone, a help meet, in Hebrew is support, a person was needed to sustain Adam and God created the woman.

“And the LORD God formed man of the dust of the ground, and breathed into his nostrils the breath of life; and man became a living soul.” Genesis 2.7 . Genesis describes the creation of man, using the word "יָצַא" (yatsa) in the context to give shape. Isaiah 64:8 uses "יוֹצֵר" (yotzer), that comes from the same root and compares God's creative action to a potter shaping a lump of clay.

Now, when God says that he formed the woman, He does not use the verb yatza, He uses the verb "בָּנָה" (banah) that means: to outline, detail, paint or embellish.

This linguistic hint highlights the uniqueness and complexity in the creation of the woman, underlining the importance of women in the diversity and the beautification of the world, not only as created beings, but also as entities who have details and a unique beauty. This approach emphasizes the relevance and specific contribution of women in the diversity of the divine creation.

Then we could say that woman was created for God as the crown of the creation. The creation would be incomplete without the woman. The world without the woman would be incomplete, it would be short of beauty, care and grace. It would lack all that the feminine soul is called to give, it would lack the capacity of intelligence and wisdom, her participation in the spiritual strength and her dynamism to the great challenges of life. I do not even want to think how this world would be without women who are fearful of God.

Abraham Lincoln once said "The hand that rocks the cradle rules the world". The hand that rocks the cradle is the hand of a mother, able to rock a child in the most comfortable, loving and caring way. It is the same hand that rocks boys and girls, men and women that, through their values and elections, would rule the world. The hand that rocks the cradle, teaches with her life that, if we want to be loved by someone, we should love first,

love like the woman who preferred to lose her son rather than seeing him dead. 1 Kings 3:18.

The Identity of the Woman

Nowadays, there are many concepts with which society defines the identity of the woman. All of them are focused to inflame the ego of the woman, giving them a false sense “empowerment” that feeds their pride and leans them towards feminism. This creates hate to masculinity, rebellious behaviors against marriage, approving abortions and giving them rights that go against the divine will. Feminism is a satanic, antibiblical position. Feminism creates rebel women, untameable and contrary to the Biblical foundation.

Women seek constant refuge, they want to be accompanied, loved, valued and listened to, however, they look in unsuitable places, explore in broken cisterns; among these false refuges, the most dangerous is the one promoted by the revolutionary theory of feminism, since it affects the identity of women and corrodes their existence to its deepest roots.

“Eve had been perfectly happy by her husband's side in her Eden home; but, like restless modern Eves, she was flattered with the hope of entering a higher sphere than that which God had assigned her. In attempting to rise above her original position, she fell far below it. A similar result will be reached by all who are unwilling to take up cheerfully their life duties in accordance with God's plan.” AH 115.2.

Where are thousand of women searching for their identity?

In the figures of models, and making of exterior beauty a false identity, but in the end, they continue empty without horizons.

There is nothing more painful than to see women taking extreme care for their beauty, but without a purpose, with no direction on mind, to many of them we can ask: who are you? In a rambling way some of them answer that they do not know who they are.

Other false refuges that are affecting women are, low self-esteem, depression, fear, secular training, novels and management of social nets. Be silent to abuse, support feminism and machismo (male chauvinism), paralyze their gifts, feel unable to the great challenges in life, resentment, hatred and bitterness. Many women are destroyed by disappointment and live buried under the debris of resentment. So, when a woman loses her identity in Christ, she will always be a victim of others, victim before

psychological, physical, verbal, sexual and religious damages.

Not to have an identity is the deterioration of the character, because it becomes an object managed by society, cultures and radical religious postulates.

A woman without identity creates homes without a solid structure, they are wives without a clear vision, are mothers without a purpose. They lose their value with the first bidder, their emotional state is conditioned to the opinion of others, their esteem is unstable, and they are fragile before bad influences.

“Women of firm principle and decided character are needed, women who believe that we are indeed living in the last days, and that we have the last solemn message of warning to be given to the world. They should feel that they are engaged in an important work in spreading the rays of light which Heaven has shed upon them. Nothing will deter this class from their duty. Nothing will discourage them in the work. They have faith to work for time and for eternity. They fear God, and will not be diverted from the work by the temptation of lucrative situations and attractive prospects. The Sabbath of the fourth commandment is sacredly kept by them, because God has placed His sanctity upon it, and has bidden them to keep it holy. They will preserve their integrity at any cost to themselves.... These are the ones who will correctly represent our faith, whose words will be fitly spoken, like apples of gold in pictures of silver.... Sisters, God calls you to work in the harvest field and help gather in the sheaves.” EV477.2

How well do you know and value yourself?

Who are you? When you look at the mirror, who do you see? Why do you think that God created you? God invites you to look at the cross of calvary because you were not born by accident, He made you for His glory. In the Bible we can find several examples of women who had fundamental roles to develop. I can mention Esther, who knew how to take advantage of her prominent position to bring salvation to her people. Jael, who by killing the general of the enemy army was able to save the people of Israel from the troops of Jabin. Deborah, who had an essential role in the fight in favor of her people. Hannah, who conceived a son who was Samuel, the prophet that Israel needed. Mary, in her only unique and privileged role to be the mother of the Messiah. Each one of these women had a purpose that was different to others. However, what all of them have in common, is that they

fulfilled the mission for which they were created. They did what they had to do.

These examples showed us that in the Bible there is no secondary purpose of the woman, but it showed us that there were feminine characters that were protagonist and essential in the story of salvation. Also, these stories show us that there is no pigeonholed function for women: nor as a mom, neither a wife or a warrior. Each woman must find her own vocation. The reason of her existence. When we find our real purpose, and we live faithful to that vocation, it is then that we can get the best of ourselves.

“You are responsible for the ability which God has given you. You may, by making the most of your privileges, fit yourself for a position of usefulness and duty. You need not be aspiring to do a great work, aspiring after great things; but you may be doing your work, small though it may be, feeling your responsibility of doing this work to God's acceptance... In spiritual things every man and woman has his or her own peculiar sphere and vocation. The interest God requires will be proportionate to the amount of entrusted capital according to the measure of the gift of Christ....” TDG 243.

WHO OWNS YOUR INDIVIDUALITY?

Many women lose their individuality by surrendering it to anti-biblical opinions, fashion, pagan philosophies or male chauvinist concepts. They become manageable objects; they fall like autumn leaves carried by the wind. God warns through His servants: “But while you are to blend as one, neither of you is to lose his or her individuality in the other. God is the owner of your individuality. Of Him you are to ask: What is right? What is wrong? How may I best fulfill the purpose of my creation?” AH 103.

“Her individuality cannot be merged into that of her husband, for she is the purchase of Christ. It is a mistake to imagine that with blind devotion she is to do exactly as her husband says in all things.” AH 116.

The warning against the blind surrendering to the husband's will suggests that submission should not imply losing one's own discernment and autonomy. What would have happened if Abigail, wife of Nabal, would have surrendered blindly to the opinion and position of her husband before the request of King David? The story would have been different for her and her many servants. It is important that each woman preserves her individuality and autonomy even inside the marriage.

“The wife and mother should not sacrifice her strength and allow her powers to lie dormant, leaning wholly upon her husband. Her individuality

cannot be merged in his. She should feel that she is her husband's equal—to stand by his side, she faithful at her post of duty and he at his.” AH 231.

Any initiative to deteriorate the identity of the woman is an initiative to demolish the solid bases of the redemption itself, it is an attack against the design of God and whoever threatens against His design, threatens against God. Christianity does not oppress women; it gives them freedom in the midst of subjection.

Each woman who truly knows Jesus will not allow her identity to be deteriorated and lose her individuality in Him. Christ is your best friend and He is ready to help you keep your identity in Him. Are you willing to surrender daily to this best friend? May our prayer be: Lord help me to be by your side everyday. Amen.



Preservation of the FAMILY According to God

By
Pr. Pablo Hunger

Every family's dream is to have their own house, their refuge. How many sacrifices are taken to achieve this dream of having their own life? And once achieved it must be maintained so that the house stays beautiful. But what is a beautiful house for, if there is not a good relationship between the members of the family or there exists tension between the spouses? Many even avoid returning home because they don't want to encounter with their spouse.

The prophets counseled the kings, and the people, saying:

“Except the LORD build the house, they labour in vain that build it: except the LORD keep the city the watchman waketh but in vain.” Psalms 127:1

“... but as for me and my house, we shall serve the LORD.” Joshua 24:15

“... Thus saith the LORD, Set thine house in order ...” Isaiah 38:1

“... for mine house shall be called an house of prayer for all people.” Isaiah 56:7

If you want a house of blessings and prosperity, these words are the best recommendations for your home.

In these words, there's a detail that affects all of the aspects of the home. It is to include the “Lord”. Then, He is the constructor, and we are His servants. This is the difference between the plan that God has designed and the plans of humans. Imagine that you are building a house but you don't know the construction laws of the government. When you request the approval of the corresponding department, they will tell you that all of the work was in vain, because you haven't built according to the regulations. Surely, they will ask you to redo the work before you can live happily in your home.

God has some regulations for the home. Applying them will give as a result a happy home, with decisions that will lead to a good purpose, full of expressions of true love, with communication that elevates, with feelings that are based on the divine principles, with constructive plans, and with ideals that have touches of happiness, warmth, and peace.

We all desire to learn these regulations so we can obtain good results.

I remember a young couple in Austria that had a son and newborn twins. They were regularly assisting the culinary classes that we offered to the community. After observing my family and how we educated our young children, one day the husband said to me: “We like how you educate your children. You have some rules that are different from the rest, and I see that you have a clear line and know what you need to do and how you need to do it. I want my wife to learn from you. How do you know that your way of educating is correct?” They allowed me to visit them personally and to read in the Bible the rules that God has left for us for a home of joy and prosperity.

Society unfortunately chooses its paths and builds its homes without consulting with God. The youth let themselves be controlled by their emotions and look for a partner that pleases their eyes, without

considering the spiritual values. Many of them even decide to live together without being married. After seeing the reality of life, they separate once again. Their feelings and emotions are connected with their actions, which destroy their apparent happiness.

Building according to the divine rules means to sit down, study and to understand His law. Every day we should sit down to read the Bible as a family. We must also communicate with God as a friend who gives us advice and teaches. And in this way, we will learn details to continue our home with joy and security.

Some families have possibly chosen a good start, but they quickly forget about God. The eagerness to acquire money drowns the good values. Early in the morning, they give their children to somebody else to take care of them, meanwhile, mom and dad go off to their job. The most important moments to establish eternal values in their tender minds and create eternal habits are neglected because there's no time.

“Thus speaketh the LORD of hosts, saying, This people say The time is not come, the time that the LORD'S house should be built.” Haggai 1:2

The same responses are heard today when you ask: When will you become closer to God? Not yet, I will think about it. I need to finish my career, I want to fix my papers, I need to look for my partner first, I need to fix my house, when my children are older, when I'm retired, etc. Don't you think it would be better to build the house of God in your home today?

But we have not realized that leaving God out of our home results in a life of bad quality, a life of low results.

“Ye have sown so much, and bring in little; ye eat, but ye have not enough; ye drink, but ye are not fulfilled with drink; ye clothe you, but there is none warm, and he that earneth wages earneth wages to put it into a bag with holes.” Haggai 1:6.

“It is in vain for you to rise up early, to sit up late, to eat the bread of sorrows: for so he giveth his beloved sheep.” Psalms 127:2

The blessings of God come by putting God first in our lives and by building according to the divine laws.

Satan's master plan to destroy the family:

I've got a house in the countryside that needed a complete renovation. In one corner it was affected by termites. These small animals, for decades,

had slowly been eating a beam of wood and its foundation. It reminded me of how Satan is trying to sabotage the foundations of many homes. Slowly and with constant efforts looking to find a small space in homes that destroys the firm principles that God has placed for the building of these homes.

Since it was an old house and, because it would need to be renovated either way, in addition to eliminating the termites, one of the first jobs that had to be done was replacing the wooden beam and restoring the foundation that had been affected.

If you detect the work of the enemy in your home, then you must repair the foundation. Although it may seem unbelievable, with just a hydraulic jack capable of lifting 8 tons and a group of people with experience little by little it was able to lift up the house, replace the wooden beam that was affected, and restore the foundation. It would have been impossible for me to have done it alone, but the experience of those friends was enough to restore the house. If you have decided to restore the divine principles, God will work through his agents and the Holy Spirit to restore your home.

All you need is faith, patience and to put your life in the hands of God. Even in your home the Lord can lift up more than 8 tons of problems and give you happiness.

What are these tiny termites that try to destroy the family? Let us mention four attacks of the enemy towards the family:

1. Division: “Be sober, be vigilant; because your adversary the devil, as a roaring lion, walketh about, seeking whom he may devour.” 1 Peter 5:8 Satan searches to introduce division within the families by forming disputes and conflicts. This could be manifested through disputes, lack of a forgiving spirit, lack of humility, lack of communication, and fractured relationships, which will weaken the connections in the family. More than often pride is an obstacle to admitting mistakes and asking for forgiveness.

“Parents should be careful not to allow the spirit of dissension to creep into the home; for this is one of Satan's agents to make his impression on the character. If parents will strive for unity in the home by inculcating the

principles that govern the life of Christ, dissension will be driven out, and unity and love will abide there. "AH 178.3

2. Selfishness and Individualism: "proud, blasphemes, disobedient to parents, unthankful, unholy. 2 Timothy 3:2.

"Human beings belong to one great family, —the family of God. The Creator designed that they should respect and love one another, ever manifesting a pure, unselfish interest in one another's welfare. But Satan's aim has been to lead men to self-first; and yielding themselves to his control, they have developed a selfishness that has filled the world with misery and strife, setting human beings at variance with one another." CS 24.1

How many dishonour Christ and misrepresent His character in the home circle! How many do not manifest patience, forbearance, forgiveness, and true love! ... The life of Jesus is full of kindness and love. AH 178.

3. Destroying the Fundamental Morals: "From whence come wars and fightings among you? come they not hence, even of your lusts that war in your members? Ye lust, and have not: ye kill, and desire to have, and cannot obtain: ye fight and war, yet ye have not, because ye ask not. Ye ask, and receive not, because ye ask amiss, that ye may consume it upon your lusts. Ye adulterers and adulteresses, know ye not that the friendship of the world is enmity with God? whosoever therefore will be a friend of the world is the enemy of God." James 4:1-4

Satan is trying to break the fundamental values in families promoting values contrary to Biblical principles. He is using the means of communication, images, music, fashion and food, but also teachers, leaders, and liberal laws to influence the minds about Biblical moral values. The low moral level of the society is tolerated by the government and the churches.

The devil wants you to participate in what he offers, the so-called "pleasures" that not only lead to sin but also leave you dull, dishonest, and immoral. Undermining the holiness of marriage by promoting unfaithfulness and modern "polygamy" that leads to broken families. Some effects of a broken marriage are anxiety, depression, a feeling of loss, and feelings of abandonment. The rupture of a marriage may also

provoke aggression, stress, an impact on your ability to concentrate, academic challenges, loss of trust, loss of compromise, loss of communication as well as financial challenges, risk of abusing substances, and the children may repeat the example of the parents in the future, feeling that they may easily abandon a relationship if it doesn't work out well.

4. Attack towards parental rights and honour: "The rod and reproof give wisdom: but a child left to himself bringeth his mother to shame."
Proverbs 29:15

The Bible teaches children to honour and obey their parents, and it is the privilege of the parents to guide them, nurture them, correct them, and show them genuine love. There are two extremes in educative styles that a Christian home must avoid. One is the liberal education style. The children have all the freedom. They can choose when to eat, what to eat, when to go to bed, how to manage their time, in the end, they are the ones ruling over their parents. The other is the authoritarian style, children cannot express their feelings, and thoughts and take part when the family makes decisions. Both styles can develop rebellious kids.

"Children have sensitive, loving natures. They are easily pleased and easily made unhappy. By gentle discipline in loving words and acts, mothers may bind their children to their hearts. To manifest severity and to be exacting with children are great mistakes. Uniform firmness and unimpassioned control are necessary to the discipline of every family. Say what you mean calmly, move with consideration, and carry out what you say without deviation." 3T 532.2

"Rebellion is too frequently established in the hearts of children through the wrong discipline of the parents, when if a proper course had been taken, the children would have formed good and harmonious characters."— CG 237.4

Gods' Original Plan for Marriage and the Family:

1. Unity and comradeship: "Fulfil ye my joy, that ye be likeminded, having the same love, being of one accord, of one mind." *Philippians 2:2*.

According to God's original plan, the family is designed to be a fountain of unity and comradeship. The bond between the members of the family

promotes emotional support, love, and a feeling of belonging.

"The more closely the members of a family are united in their work in the home, the more uplifting and helpful will be the influence that father and mother and sons and daughters will exert outside the home." AH 37.5

"Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave unto his wife: and they shall be one flesh." Genesis. 2:24.

This verse points out the sacred union between a man and his wife. The phrase "Therefore shall a man leave his father and his mother":: a separation of the two-family links to create a new and independent union. The use of the word "and they shall be one flesh" means a strong and unbreakable bond between husband and wife, accepting the compromise, the devotion in love, but also the need to do things together in marriage. The phrase "and they shall be one flesh" points to the profound unity and interconnection of the matrimonial relationship, not only physical or financial but also emotional and spiritual.

2. Love and sacrifice: The design of God for the family emphasizes the principle of love and selfless sacrifice. The members of the family are called to love one another like they love themselves. Every part of the family prioritizes the well-being of others. It builds trust and deepens connections within the family.

Ephesians 5 is about the love of the husband and the respect of the wife.

The love of the husband:

- **Acts of sacrifice:** The husband can demonstrate love by making sacrifices for the well-being and happiness of his wife and children. This could imply renouncing personal preferences, limiting the usage of news or social media platforms, and giving a break to the family by going out on a walk or having a drink together.
- **Words of Care and Effective Communication:** "There are many men who never know how starved is the heart of the wife for words of tender appreciation and affection." 3T 527.1

Having an open and honest conversation is not very easy for most men. You can learn to do this by asking open questions, such as: How do you feel about...? Can you help me to better understand this? Is there

anything you need from me right now? How can we work together to find a solution? What are your objectives in this? Is there anything on your mind that you would like for us to talk about? And don't forget that listening to your wife is an important part of good communication in a marriage.

- **Acts of Service:** Simple gestures like helping with the duties of the home or taking care of the children and other responsibilities show the willingness to lighten the burden of the family.

Respect of the Wife:

- **Affirmation and Encouragement:** Recognizing and valuing the efforts of your husband, whether they be small or big, strengthen your connection of love. Many times, wives don't know how to recognize the efforts of their husband, but you could say: "I admire your kindness and generosity", "Your humour brings light to our home", "Thank you for working so hard and never giving up", "You show so much responsibility and dedication in your work", "I appreciate your disposition to listen and understand my feelings". "Your encouragement gives me strength", "I am thankful for the love and warmth that you bring to our family." Be specific when recognizing the efforts of your husband, emphasizing the good aspects of his character, his devoted actions and what you like about him.
- **Actions to Encourage your Husband:** Respect is demonstrated through actions of support. This could imply actively supporting your husbands hopes and dreams, encourage personal growth and provide a sense of safety. For example, if he has to transport something heavy to repair it, you can tell him: "I'm coming with you, I know its heavy".
- **Recognizing leadership:** Means to respect the role of the husband as the leader of the family, recognize his decisions and discuss important topics together." We must have the Spirit of God, or we can never have harmony in the home. The wife, if she has the spirit of Christ, will be careful of her words; she will control her spirit, she will be submissive, and yet will not feel that she is a bonds slave, but a companion to her husband. If the

husband is a servant of God, he will not lord it over his wife; he will not be arbitrary and exacting.” AH 118.1

“There is One who stands higher than the husband to the wife; it is her Redeemer, and her submission to her husband is to be rendered as God has directed— “as it is fit in the Lord.” AH 116.1

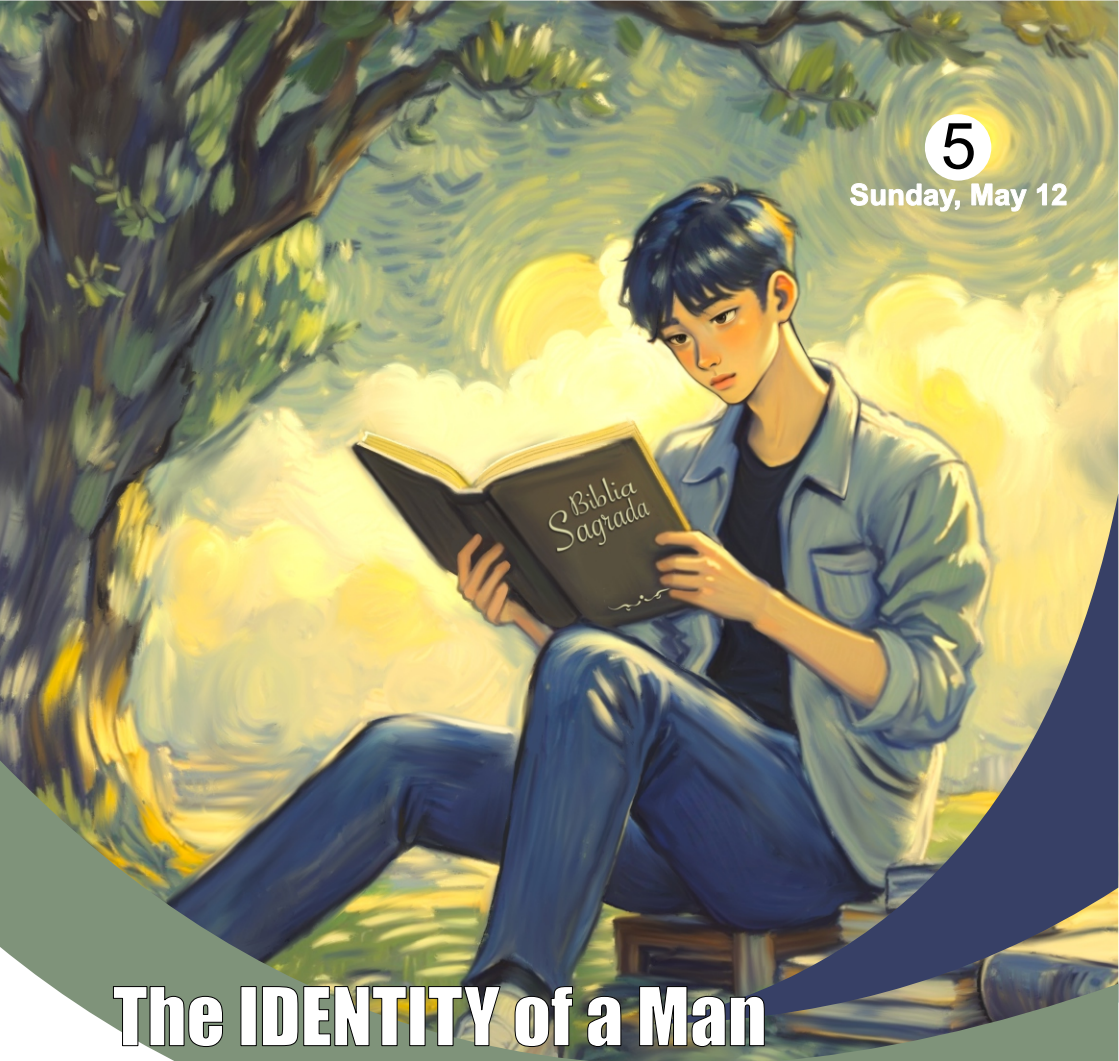
“Never forget that you are to make the home bright and happy for yourselves and your children by cherishing the Saviour's attributes. If you bring Christ into the home, you will know good from evil. You will be able to help your children to be trees of righteousness, bearing the fruit of the Spirit.” AH 17..4

God's plan for the family implies the transmission of Biblical values and moral principles from one generation to the next. The parents must be a guide teaching the members of the family uprightness, integrity, faith, the fear of the Lord and the importance of living according to the commandments of God. This transmission of values will be of blessing to the society. Let's allow our homes to be based on God.

Amen.

5

Sunday, May 12



The IDENTITY of a Man According to God

By
Sis. Elizabeth Cabrera

After the earth with its teeming animal and vegetable life had been called into existence, man, the crowning work of the Creator, and the one for whom the beautiful earth had been fitted up, was brought upon the stage of action. To him was given dominion over all that his eye could behold; for "God said, Let Us make man in Our image, after Our likeness: and let them have dominion over ...all the earth.... So God created man in His own image; ...male and female created He them." PP 44.3

"Man was to bear God's image, both in outward resemblance and in character. Christ alone is "the express image" (Hebrews 1:3) of the Father; but man was

formed in the likeness of God. His nature was in harmony with the will of God. His mind was capable of comprehending divine things. His affections were pure; his appetites and passions were under the control of reason. He was holy and happy in bearing the image of God and in perfect obedience to His will.” PP45.2

“Our first parents, though created innocent and holy, were not placed beyond the possibility of wrongdoing. God made them free moral agents, capable of appreciating the wisdom and benevolence of His character and the justice of His requirements, and with full liberty to yield or to withhold obedience...Without freedom of choice, his obedience would not have been voluntary, but forced. There could have been no development of character”. PP48.4-PP49.1

We all know well how the story unfolded. Adam and Eve were tempted and sinned, thus surrendering all dominion and authority over the earth to Satan, who has always had a plan of destruction and death, which we can verify throughout history with various examples.

The enemy in his plan seeks to destroy the image and likeness of God in man. He began with evolution and those theories that degrade us as animals, amphibians that changed and evolved over the years, and he takes away from our minds the perfection of man as the crown of creation and the authority given to Adam to rule over the earth and the animals.

“Man was originally endowed with noble powers and a well-balanced mind. He was perfect in his being, and in harmony with God. His thoughts were pure, his aims holy. But through disobedience, his powers were perverted, and selfishness took the place of love...It was the tempter's purpose to thwart the divine plan in man's creation, and fill the earth with woe and desolation. And he would point to all this evil as the result of God's work in creating man.” SC 17.1

Self-Knowledge

Our identity is a prominent topic in contemporary society. Identity can be defined as the set of traits or characteristics of a person that distinguishes them from others in a group. For believers, the fundamental source of identity has always been and will continue to be God and His Word. We are God's masterpiece, created in His image, which implies that we possess traits or characteristics similar to our Creator. This is the foundation of our identity. However, the fall of man has distorted that image and likeness of God in us. Sin has obscured our true identity. Often, we seek our worth in achievements, appearances, possessions, or social approval. But the Bible warns us, in 1 John 2:16: "For all that is in the world, the lust of the flesh, and the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life, is not of the Father, but is of the world."

“To know oneself is a great knowledge... Self-knowledge leads to humility and to trust in God, but it does not take the place of efforts for self-improvement. He

who realizes his own deficiencies will spare no pains to reach the highest possible standard of physical, mental, and moral excellence." 1MCP 4.5

It's incredible how people are focused on their education, intellectual preparation, or the development of their skills for their living, and although, none of these is wrong, often we forget or lose sight of the most important thing: our relationship with God and His plan for each of His children. In the Bible, we have a well-known example in Moses, a Hebrew child raised and educated in all the wisdom and military strategies of Egypt. One might think that he would be an excellent liberator, that he could have staged a coup, knowing all the military strategies from the inside and with the power he had, he could have prepared a rebellion and led his people to independence and liberation. However, all that knowledge separated him from his intimate relationship with God; he lost his identity, and it was necessary for him to spend 40 years in the wilderness unlearning all his Egyptian education and learning to depend on God, to trust in God, not in his own strength but in the power of God. He carried out the liberation of his people, but miraculously, exalting the power of God and showing to all nations that the God of Israel was superior to all other gods.

Consequences of a Man Without Identity

A man who does not know his identity in Christ is like a leaf blown by the wind, influenced by any current of thought or popular culture. This lack of identity can lead to insecurity, sin, and ultimately separation from God. We must be aware that we are "...a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for His own; that ye should shew forth the praises of him who hath called you out of darkness into his marvellous light" (1 Peter 2:9).

Unfortunately, those who do not have a living connection with God will lose their identity and purpose and slide further and further down the wrong path. "When the deceiver begins his work of seduction, he frequently finds disparity in tastes and habits; but by making great displays of piety, he gains confidence, and when he has done so, his cunning deceitful power is exercised in his own way to carry out his plans. By associating themselves with these dangerous elements...They lose their identity and become the shadow of his seducer." 2JT35.3

How Well Do We Know Ourselves?

"Knowing yourself is great knowledge. True self-knowledge leads to a humility that prepares the way for the Lord to develop the mind and mold and discipline the character." 2MCP 366.1.

But we must be careful; Jeremiah 17:9 tells us, "The heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately wicked: who can know it?" On our own, we cannot fully know ourselves. Only through God and His Word can we discover our true

identity and value.

Our value is immense in the eyes of God. So much so that He sent His only Son to die for us. "But God commendeth his love toward us, in that, while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us" (Romans 5:8).

As children of God, it is essential that we understand our true identity in Christ. Only then can we live the abundant life and purpose that God has for us. It is our duty as a family to help each other discover and affirm this identity in Christ.

The Man with a Christian Identity as a Father

The Bible teaches us that the role of the Christian man in the family as a husband and father is of utmost importance. In Ephesians 5:25, the word of the Lord tells us, "Husbands, love your wives, even as Christ also loved the church, and gave himself for it." What a great example and lofty goal husbands should strive for in their relationship with their wives. They should love, care for, provide for their every need, and be willing to give their lives for their wives. And the word of the Lord tells us later in Ephesians 6:4, "And, ye fathers, provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord." In other words, they should lovingly guide their children in the path of faith and righteousness.

Ellen G. White in "The Adventist Home" tells us, that the father's place in the home is sacred and dignified. He is to regard himself as God's steward, and as such is responsible for the souls of his children. He is to teach them and to command his household after him, even his wife and children. He is to educate his family for God, and is to train his children to obey and respect the claims of their heavenly Father.

The above mentioned highlights the importance of the father in a Christian family. He should assume his role as the spiritual guide and protector of his family, leading them to a deeper relationship with God and teaching them to be a blessing to others.

The Bible presents a clear model of Christian fatherhood in the figure of Abraham. In Genesis 18:19, God says of Abraham, "For I know him, that he will command his children and his household after him, and they shall keep the way of the Lord, to do justice and judgment." This emphasizes that a Christian father should be a spiritual leader in his home, setting an example of faith and righteousness for his children. His responsibility is not limited to providing material things but also includes instructing them in faith and Christian values, and most importantly, setting an example of obedience and righteousness to the things of God. Often, our actions speak louder than words, and fathers with a clear Christian identity will demonstrate in practice how to obey God's Law and serve the Lord in all circumstances.

The Christian father with a clear identity should be a model of character and virtue for his children. He should be the priest of his own family and should live an exemplary life so that his wife and children respect and love him. He should be a man of prayer, have a living faith in God, and should seek divine guidance for all things at all times.

Furthermore, the Bible reminds us in Proverbs 22:6: "Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it." Christian parents have the responsibility to teach their children the principles of faith and help them develop a personal relationship with God from an early age.

How Much Are We Worth?

"The price paid for our redemption, the infinite sacrifice of our heavenly Father in giving His Son to die for us, should give us exalted conceptions of what we may become through Christ. As the inspired apostle John beheld the height, the depth, the breadth of the Father's love toward the perishing race, he was filled with adoration and reverence; and, failing to find suitable language in which to express the greatness and tenderness of this love, he called upon the world to behold it. "Behold, what manner of love the Father hath bestowed upon us, that we should be called the sons of God." 1 John 3:1. What a value this places upon man!... By assuming human nature, Christ elevates humanity. Fallen men are placed where, through connection with Christ, they may indeed become worthy of the name "sons of God." SC 15.1

"The value of a soul, who can estimate? Would you know its worth, go to Gethsemane, and there watch with Christ through those hours of anguish, when He sweat as it were great drops of blood. Look upon the Saviour uplifted on the cross. Hear that despairing cry, "My God, My God, why hast Thou forsaken Me?" Mark 15:34. Look upon the wounded head, the pierced side, the marred feet. Remember that Christ risked all. For our redemption, heaven itself was imperiled. At the foot of the cross, remembering that for one sinner Christ would have laid down His life, you may estimate the value of a soul." COL 196.4

God has a wonderful plan for each of His children. He values us so much that He carried out the plan of salvation to rescue us. Let us allow the Lord to work in our lives, so that, like David, we may have a heart after God's own heart, despite our shortcomings. Let us beseech the Lord to show His will in our lives, finding our true identity, and like Paul, recognizing our identity, may we be transformed. Like Joshua, may we be exemplary parents and serve the Lord together with our families. And like Moses, through humility and detachment, may we become true representatives of God on Earth, declaring as Paul did: "For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain" (Philippians 1:21). Amen.



The Family IDENTIFYING Itself with the Church

By
Pr. Víctor Carbajal

Then Ruth's mother-in-law Naomi said to her, 'My daughter, should I not look for a home for you, so all will be well with you?'” Ruth 3:1. “The house is the sanctuary for the family, and the closet or the grove the most retired place for individual worship, but the church is the sanctuary for the congregation” (2TT 193.3).

Human beings have always identified with their beliefs. During the time of the patriarchs, families were spiritual sanctuaries, its members' beliefs were strengthened, perpetuating the knowledge of the truths of salvation and the

teachings they received through the prophets and patriarchs. The missionary activity was such, that many renowned pagans and common people accepted the knowledge of one true God; for example, some were members of the Israeli nation, like Rahab and Ruth, and others, like Naaman, remained in their cities with the little light they had received. In the life of this last person, a girl was the instrument chosen by the Lord to be a light in a family that was pagan by culture and birth. It was evident that each member always identified with their faith, city, or church. In regards to this, we will see relevant biblical details in our study.

The family and the church in biblical times

In the Old Testament. The Eternal, when creating Adam and Eve, instituted marriage, the family and children were included through the words: “Be fruitful and multiply; fill the earth and subdue it...” Genesis 1:28. Eve said that children were not only by human will: “I have obtained a son from the Lord.” Genesis 4:1.

In Adam and Eve's family, the first two children received the same spiritual education, both understood that God demanded reverence and praise; but while Abel acknowledged he was a sinner, Cain partially obeyed and by the nature of his offering showed that he did not need a Savior.

The story of the first family on earth was overshadowed by the first fratricide, after the greatest disaster of the human family (the introduction of sin into our world). Since then, our families have been in crisis due to divorces, separations, and arguments, even attempts against the life of the spouse. Therefore, children will be affected the most, resulting in other greater evils, not only perpetuating the evil but also extending and aggravating the consequences.

In biblical times, Israelite families identified with their faith, spiritual principles, and of course, with their nation: “I will take you as My people, and I will be your God...” Exodus 6:7. That is why families defended and strived for the aggrandizement of their people: “Blessed are you, Israel! (Adventist Reformers) Who is like you, a people saved by the Lord? He is your shield and helper and your glorious sword. Your enemies will cower before you, and you will tread on their heights.” Deuteronomy 33:29. “Be of good courage, and let us be strong for our people and for the cities of our God. And may the Lord do what is good in His sight.” 2 Samuel 10:12.

Among those that stand out in the biblical annals, are families whose

identities were notable among other people and even within their own; for example: Noah's family who was all saved; Abraham's family for their leading and fidelity to the Lord, guiding the people towards the promised land; Isaac's family stands out for its unwavering loyalty to the principles of a monogamous marriage; and we cannot forget, Jacob for his faith, self-denial, and firmness, despite certain unrecommended aspects. Jacob obtained the forgiveness he greatly desired by earning a new name that reflected his repentance and salvation: Israel, "overcomer," which prefigures the nomination of the spiritual family in the last stage of the worldwide church. Let us also remember Moses, whose family walked with him and supported him to wisely lead his nation; who, because of his unique patience, humility, and resignation, failing only once, interceded for those who tried to harm him yet he loved them more than himself. For Moses, the people were also his family.

To summarize, the families that existed before Jesus appeared, identified with his principles, government, and church, that through faith and love towards the Eternal, remained a faithful remnant. They did not lose their true belief identity, maintaining themselves until the time arrived of the Son of Man, who emerged within the family circle of Joseph and Mary, members of the Jewish church or the people of Israel.

The verses mentioned above reveal the deep affection towards the Creator, which extends to the church or the Lord's chosen people. The majority were aware of the mission and vision of their existence since they were not just any people among other nations.

IN THE NEW TESTAMENT. With the Divine Master's arrival among us, a noticeable consideration was experienced in the roles of women, wives, and mothers. There was more stability among families because polygamy officially disappeared from the Lord's church, since it was not the expressed will of God but instead, it was tolerated because of the hardness of the heart of people. (Matthew 19:3-9). Let us think about the words of Jesus: "...and if the members of a family fight among themselves, the family will be destroyed." Matthew 12:25. There is an ultimate blessing for the families of the earth expressed by the Great Architect, "...by saying to Abraham, in your descendants, all the families of the earth will be blessed." Acts 3:25. This is how the church was sustained in the Old Testament and continued in the New Testament, sharing this blessed hope of comfort and salvation for

thousands of years. Families were led in unity, transmitting this message to both their family members and the Gentiles. We find in God's Book: "They answered: Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you and your family will be saved." Acts 16:31; the inspired record is even more encouraging and motivating: "At that hour of the night the jailer took them and washed their wounds; then immediately he and all his household were baptized." Acts 16:33. After such punishment, presenting their faith and conviction in the Teacher of Galilee, would give the Lord's servants intense satisfaction and joy. The Holy Scriptures inform us about them: "Now when he had brought them into his house, he set food before them; and he rejoiced, having believed in God with all his household." Acts 16:34. The apostle Paul, in a well-documented evangelistic message, states: "...as even some of your own poets have said, 'For we also are His descendants.'" Acts 17:28. It is astounding that the Divinity includes us in its ineffable love, in the great cosmic family, which includes the angels, inhabitants of the innumerable worlds, and obviously the human race, even though we do not possess anything that could recommend or make us worthy of such distinction and consideration; since the Divine record declares: "What is man, that he should be clean? and he which is born of a woman, that he should be righteous? Behold, he putteth no trust in his saints; yea, the heavens are not clean in his sight. How much more abominable and filthy is man, which drinketh iniquity like water?" Job 15:14-16.

Given such a description of our condition, the Lord in his infinite mercy places us into the heavenly family, repopulating heaven with those saved by faith in the merits of Christ's righteousness. In the days of the early church, the examples of families that stand out for their heroism of faith, prayer, and dedication to the Savior, include the parents of John the Baptist, whose remnant family awaited the consolation of Israel through the advent of the Messiah. And John being born in the family bosom was considered by Jesus himself as "the greatest among those born of a woman." They identified themselves with the church because of their trust in God and Zacariah continued his activity as a retired priest.

Timothy's family is registered in the pages of the Word of God, mentioning the faith of his grandmother Lois and his mother Eunice, as mentors to this servant of Jesus, despite the pagan origin (of the father) of this family. However, the knowledge of the redemptive message was the trigger to produce fruits that glorified the Almighty and to benefit the church. It is

necessary to mention the family of the Savior of the world, who was also part of a family like every mortal, contributing to its support, and identifying himself with the church and with his people (John 1:11; Luke 4:16) to fulfill the mission of the families believing in a true God.

The family in the dark middle ages

It's through afflictions and trials that church members are purified and prepared to enter through the heavenly portals: "Confirming the encouragement of the disciples, exhorting them to remain in the faith, and that through many tribulations we must enter the kingdom of God." Acts 14:22. It was through these disciplinary measures that the church and families became strong and firm due to the unbreakable ties that united them and the brotherly love for non-believers. The Master also taught to love one's enemies and not pay evil for evil, but repay evil with good. This was so irresistibly strong that in the center of the metropolis of the world, Rome, the Iron Empire, there were monuments of faithfulness for the glory of the Lord.

We have records from Divine inspiration regarding the power of Christian education in the family: "Foremost among those who were called to lead the church from the darkness of popery into the light of a purer faith, stood Martin Luther... sprang from the ranks of poverty... Hardship, privation, and severe discipline were the school in which Infinite Wisdom prepared Luther for the important mission of his life" (GC 120.1, 2). Here mentioned, is the power of faithful members of the church's influence on the family and likewise the influence and power of the family on the church, even when it does not correspond to its high calling, it is an extraordinary benefit with enormous results that can be perceived. Throughout history we find numerous examples of men and women renowned for their faith, and work in favor of the church and evangelization, such as John Hus; here are some highlighted words: "Little did that mother realize how her prayer was to be answered" (GC 98.1).

The contemporary family

"For a son dishonors his father, a daughter rises up against her mother, a daughter-in-law against her mother-in-law— a man's enemies are the members of his own household." Micah 7:6. "They will be divided, father against son and son against father, mother against daughter and daughter

against mother, mother-in-law against daughter-in-law and daughter-in-law against mother-in-law.” Luke 12:53. Dear fathers, this happens in our world even among those who know the truth of Jesus. It is encouraging that the Creator compares his kingdom with your investiture, function, and responsibility as the father of the family (Matthew 20:1). Therefore, its development, well-being, and functionality depend on your direction and leadership; our role is so important that even the salvation of the family members depends largely on the father (Luke 12:39, 42) and, remember my brother, if we do not perform our responsibility as we should, the Creator and Father of the Family, will overlook us for our inability and negligence, seeking other resources (Luke 14:21) for His will to be fulfilled.

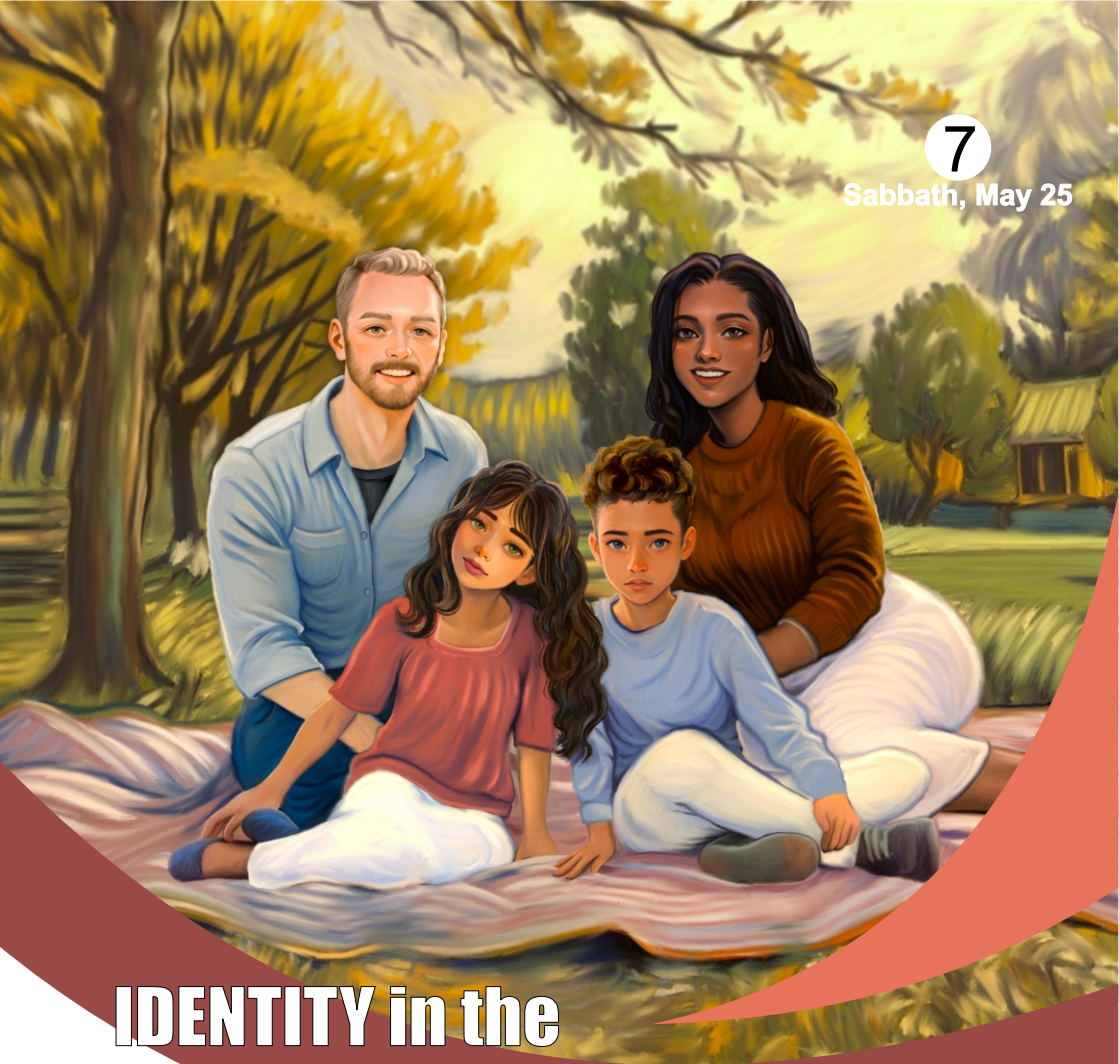
Dear bretheren, we live in a world where emotions, sentimentalism, and passion prevail over reason, will, conscience, and definitely over spiritual principles based on written inspiration; the world identifies with what it loves, appreciates, admires, and idolizes (a singer, actor or actress, an athlete, or your country's soccer team). Are we moved by the message of the cross? Does our heart burn when we hear topics about Christ? Are we enthused by the studies and topics of justification by faith? Let us reflect on the following: “Many who profess to be Christians become excited over worldly enterprises, and their interest is awakened for new and exciting amusements, while they are coldhearted, and appear as if frozen, in the cause of God. Here is a theme, poor formalist, which is of sufficient importance to excite you. Eternal interests are here involved. Upon this theme **it is sin** to be calm and unimpassioned. The scenes of Calvary call for the deepest emotion. Upon this subject you will be excusable if you manifest enthusiasm.” (2T 212.3).

Final thoughts

Our children will be moved by the object of our emotions, they learn from us: preferences, practices, convictions, and even feelings, mistakes, and thoughtless words. Be extremely careful! No matter what, consequences will come and regret will not solve anything at all.

If there is no identity with the church, generally we will not hesitate to go to any other church easily, stating that now we are better and that the “truth” is on our side, and greatly revealing that we were in error. The Word of God shows a good number of men and women who suffered humiliation, detractions, marginalization, etc; but they prevailed because it is true that

the truth is only Christ, the Divinity, his Law, his Word, and his doctrine. “God has a people upon the earth who in faith and holy hope are tracing down the roll of fast-fulfilling prophecy...” (1TT 503.3); “Has God no living church? He has a church, but it is the church militant, not the church triumphant. We are sorry that there are defective members, that there are tares amid the wheat.” (TM 45.1); “God is leading out a people. He has a chosen people, a church on the earth, whom He has made the depositaries of His law.” (GRC 44.3). May the Lord guide us in our convictions and confidence in biblical truths; may it not be obscured by resentment, foolishness, anger, biblical ignorance, immaturity, or lack of individuality and spiritual maturity. Amen.



IDENTITY in the Family

By
Pr. Samuel Maravilha

When young people reach a certain period in their lives, they begin to plan their future. Normally, they picture their future with a husband or wife so that their remaining days here on earth may not be lived in solitude, but with a companion or a partner. From this moment on, their mind, like a compass, begins to search for the person they imagine to be ideal for their life goals. The woman, more often than the man, begins to dream in every sense. She may dream of physical traits

or maybe mental characteristics (wisdom). Generally, she also gives high priority to the man's financial status, and seeks someone to compliment her personality, but many times she forgets to look at the emotional and most importantly, the spiritual traits of her future spouse.

"Never!" in my advice, should anyone seek their spouse without consulting the Bible or the Spirit of Prophecy, because in this subject or "...in many other matters, you will have prophetic guidance to form a happy family, which is God's plan for all people." (Adventist Home, pg. 3)

If we really want to form an ideal home, building a heavenly home, we must seek God's guidance. Many homes today are falling apart because they sought a spouse as Samson sought, even going against the wishes of their parents. "Then his father and his mother said unto him, Is there never a woman among the daughters of thy brethren, or among all my people, that thou goest to take a wife of the uncircumcised Philistines? And Samson said unto his father, Get her for me; for she pleaseth me well... And he went down, and talked with the woman; and she pleased Samson well. Judges 14:3, 7.

Interestingly, Samson ended up losing his eyes and also losing the woman who pleased his eyes. Marriages like Samson's have become very common and most of them, without wanting to generalize, are of fleeting duration because they are far from God's design for human beings. The family, which is the heart (or nucleus) of society, of the church, and of the nation, must find its identity rooted in God, who is the author and organizer of the human family. The family identity carries divine ancestry, as the family institution was created by God.

Never Regret Getting Married (frustration, disappointment)

If you are a Christian and already have an established home, and if you believe in the Omniscience of God, you will never question your marriage. If your lives are in the hands of the Creator, He will grant you all your life's dreams, including your marriage. The frustration you may come to feel often does not stem from your marriage, but rather emanates from within yourself, because your trust in God is being tested. Frustration is the hand of Satan who sows doubt and distrust in the power and divine providence within your own home. If a couple places their life and future in the hands of the Creator, they will never, ever say, "I regret getting married" or, "I'm

disappointed with my marriage" because God truly is the author of happiness in their marriage. Why feed your life with thoughts and words that bring uncertainty into the home? Why say: "If I had married such and such a person, it would have been different"; "The other lady or other man would treat me better than you treat me"; "I haven't been happy since I married you". It is these words of frustration that harm a couple and, in many cases, lead their marriage to irreversible ruin. Like the example of the first couple, indirect blame is given to the Creator. Blame is given to the one who desires your wellbeing and your happiness—the one who thought of you when He said, "It is not good that the man should be alone; I will make him a help meet for him." Genesis 2:18.

Regarding the joy that filled the home of a family whom Jesus visited it is said, "Glad thanksgiving went up from that home, and God was glorified through His Son, who had restored hope to the hopeless, and strength to the stricken one. This man and his family were ready to lay down their lives for Jesus. No doubt dimmed their faith, no unbelief marred their fealty to Him who had brought light into their darkened home." – DA pg. 271.2

Many homes who still have this shadow of frustration, guilt, and disillusionments should allow Jesus to bring light and to restore the faith and security that once was held fast in Him.

Marriage is not a human institution—it is holy and divine and must be preserved as such. In the inspired writings, the Lord says that "The Sabbath and the marriage institution were ordained of God in Eden to be preserved sacred and holy. Both institutions of divine appointment have been disregarded and set at naught by men and women whose hearts are fully set in them to do evil." TSB 98.4

Family Planning

Many times, frustrations occur right at the beginning of a marriage because the focus remains on self. One wants to be caressed but doesn't want to caress. One wants to be praised but doesn't want to praise. Each one wants to be treated like a king or a queen without putting the effort in themselves. Each of them ends up suffering and the home enters a state of failure, ruin, and decay. Shouldn't this be the time to fully allow God to work?

Family planning is important, because if he wants to be king and she wants to be queen, why not bring the princes and princesses to become a part of

this royal family? Wouldn't this be the solution to restore what God desires in a home? "Many are diseased physically, mentally, and morally because their attention is turned almost exclusively to themselves. They might be saved from stagnation by the healthy vitality of younger and varying minds and the restless energy of children." AH 160. "He who gave Eve to Adam as a helpmeet ... ordained that men and women should be united in holy wedlock, to rear families whose members, crowned with honor, should be recognized as members of the family above." AH 159. Maybe this divine plan is the solution since, "Selfishness, which manifests itself in a variety of ways according to circumstances and the peculiar organization of individuals, must die. If you had children, and your mind were compelled to be called away from yourself to care for them, to instruct them, and be an example to them, it would be an advantage to you.... When two compose a family, as in your case, and there are no children to call into exercise patience, forbearance, and true love, there is need of constant watchfulness lest selfishness obtain the supremacy, lest you yourselves become the center, and you require attention, care, and interest, which you feel under no obligation to bestow upon others." AH 159.4

All this advice offered by the inspired writings must be carefully thought over, because when the Lord said, "Be fruitful and multiply and replenish the earth" (Genesis 1:28), He was not giving permission for just one family to fill the earth. Currently, it is as if many households are starting a new nation with their dozens of children. This is detrimental for the times we live in because education, being such a priority and so essential, should be a commitment from the parents and not from employees and their families. Education is often being left behind for the economic needs of a household. If family planning is not analyzed well, it will bring consequences as negative as a couple without children, whose frustration and disappointment was seen at the beginning of this reflection. If this is not met with divine guidance, not even will the presence of children help the home escape the traps of the enemy. If all these marriage-damaging frustrations multiply, and if children are already in these homes, what positive influence will be transmitted to their upbringing when they hear such negative statements and notice disappointments among their parents? None! And to make matters worse, you may be traumatizing their

young minds with the thought that all homes will fail like theirs. This brings a cloud of disappointment, doubt, and uncertainty to their future.

In All Stages of Life, One Never Stops Learning in the Family

Before concluding, I would like to present some questions: What is your role in the history of creation? Who are you in the family? What responsibility has God given you as a father or mother? Who do you represent in the smallest nucleus of society, which is the family—God or Satan?

At each stage of life, as a person discovers his or her own personality, he or she also makes his or her own choices. This day-to-day learning will shape character. We must understand that, within our own family, we will learn and set an example for others who are watching us. “It is impossible for any of us to live in such a way that we shall not cast an influence in the world. No member of the family can enclose himself within himself, where other members of the family shall not feel his influence and spirit. The very expression of the countenance has an influence for good or evil. His spirit, his words, his actions, his attitude toward others, are unmistakable. If he is living in selfishness, he surrounds his soul with a malaria’s atmosphere; while if he is filled with the love of Christ, he will manifest courtesy, kindness, tender regard for the feelings of others and will communicate to his associates, by his acts of love, a tender, grateful, happy feeling. It will be made manifest that he is living for Jesus and daily learning lessons at His feet, receiving His light and His peace. He will be able to say to the Lord, “Thy gentleness hath made me great.” 2 Samuel 22:36” AH 33.4. This song of David, recorded in chapter 22, should be the song of every family that is guided by a divine hand. I encourage you to read the entire chapter with your family.

The most important thing is that if my learning, achieved at the various stages of life, reaches my descendants, I will not be sowing frustration, disappointment, or distrust, but rather a certainty that my family has divine lineage, an ancestry of celestial origin, and that I come from exemplary descendants.

To reflect, I will leave an experience of two families that are an example of how important it is to plan our marriage and to plan what kind of education we will give our children so that they will not be frustrated and much less

doubt the Omniscience of God when we allow Him to do His will in our lives and in our families.

These two stories are of serial killer families

Stavropol, Russia – The Tarverdiyeva Family led by Inessa Tarverdiyeva and her husband, Roman Podkopaev murdered thirty people in six years. In addition to the couple, the crimes also involved their two daughters, aged 25 and 13. Among the family's victims were a 7-year-old boy and two teenagers whose eyes were cut out.

A book with a very frightening title, "Everyone in my family has killed someone", was published about the Cunningham Family. The Cunningham's were a very typical family except for one detail. Among them was a cursed aunt, an imprudent stepfather, a sarcastic sister, a mother full of desires, and a problematic brother. Living together is not easy. They had their problems, they didn't get along very well, and they weren't exactly close. But one thing united them - everyone in the family had already killed someone.

In the Bible, we see Cain, who, through his actions, left his generation marked with wickedness, prostitution, and corruption, accumulating many deaths in the family history.

Why risk the future of our families by making the same mistakes of the past, if we could rather learn from the mistakes of families who, by believing themselves capable, prevented God from helping them. Without God, they feel bitterness, sadness, deaths, disappointments, and so many other bad things. You can even say you own your senses, that you think you know when you should have children, that you know how many children you will have, but, then what? Whose responsibility is it to bring happiness to your children? Or shall we say: everyone is on their own?

In Proverbs 23:24-33 the wise Solomon says, "The father of the righteous shall greatly rejoice: and he that begetteth a wise child shall have joy of him. Thy father and thy mother shall be glad, and she that bare thee shall rejoice." That is the kind of family God want us to have—blessed and full of joy. In the following verses you can see the result of a family burdened with the curse of not knowing how to plan, of always feeling frustrated, and of showing distrust in God. "For a whore is a deep ditch... She also lieth in wait as for a prey, and increaseth the transgressors among men.... Who hath

redness of eyes? They that tarry long at the wine; they that go to seek mixed wine."

May the bitter experiences of these unfortunate families become lessons for households working to become members of the "heavenly family".

Here is some advice from the family department, "Praise ye the Lord. Blessed is the man that feareth the Lord, that delighteth greatly in his commandments. His seed shall be mighty upon earth: the generation of the upright shall be blessed." (Psalms 112: 1-2). Amen.



**International Missionary Society
Seventh-Day Adventist
Reform Movement**

General Conference

Family Department

